



an orchid Laxman picked for her from the forest. The river in which the Pandavas bathed during their exile in Dandakaranya was the river Thunga in which we bathed.

When Draupadi desired a pond to swim in, her husband Bhimasena built a dam of rocks in the Thunga for her. Not far from there lived the great sage Doorvasa who was known for his temper. Not enough water would flow into the island in which he lived because of the pond Bhima had built. He was sure to get angry and curse, and therefore Krishna warned Bhima, asking him to make three breaches in the rocky dam and propitiate Lord Siva in expiation. Bhima then hurriedly installed a lingam on the bank of the river.

We boys bathed in the swift flow of water in the breaches and worshipped the lingam and told ourselves the story many times to delight. A couple of years ago, when I revisited this lovely small temple on the bank of the Thunga, the old priest recognised me and gave finishing touches to the story I knew as a boy.

Just a year ago, he had at last done what his father and forefathers desired, which was to correct a mistake Bhima had committed in his hurry. While installing the lingam, he had forgotten to install the neutral and the female stones, one over the other, as the foundation for it. It was left to our priest in Kaliyuga to correct a blunder impetuously committed in the era of Dwapara. It cost him money, part of which he collected and part contributed himself. (Just then a group of village youth who recognised me came and complained that the Government was planning a few small dams for electricity and I must help them to fight against such dams for they would ruin agricultural land and the forest. Had not Bhima done the same, I wondered.) As I listened to the stories of the priest I thought that the fundamentalist Hindutva ideologues should know that a mistake that Bhima, a contemporary of Lord Krishna, made, could be corrected by our humble priest. We are the greatest revisionists in the world. For the followers of other great historical, Semitic religions, this revisionism is not easy.

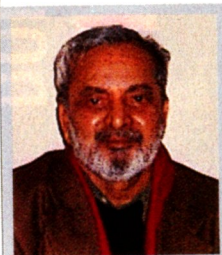
"Make adjustment"—the phrase is commonly heard all over Karnataka now. I think this is one of the ways in which we have survived as a country—by making revisions and adjustments. For people like me, the great shift in the idea of India was from the Puranic to the political and historical, and it was primarily Mahatma Gandhi who brought it about. I must add, however, that Gandhi did not abandon the Puranic, but revised it. "*Ishwar Alla tere naam*"—the line from his Ram bhajan goes against the exclusivist beliefs of both Hinduism and Islam, but it also



opposes fundamentalism without abandoning true religious piety. This was both politics and religion uniting India. The search for a nation of the kind one finds in the history of Europe can only divide India—for such a nation needs one religion, one language and one race. That is what Savarkar wanted. But our contemporary political experience tells us that if we over-centralise in the interest of unity, we are sure to balkanise.

India can't be a nation like European nations; we are a civilisation. I never tire of re-telling a story I heard from A.K. Ramanujan, a great poet and translator. Once, when he was collecting oral Ramayanas in the villages of Karnataka, he came to hear of a dialogue between Rama and Sita. Rama had been exiled to the forest and Sita was insisting that she would accompany him. Rama tried to tell her that life in a forest would be hard. In the course of the argument, when Rama came up with a strong argument, Sita replied: "In every Ramayana I know, Sita accompanies Rama to the forest. How can you then say no to me?" This is a fascinating example of the intertextuality that unites India.

A friend of mine insists that among the innumerable languages of India there are two that are understood all over the country—the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata*. A communalised India will only kill the creativity of our religious innovative spirit. Both globalised, rootless modernity and ferocious, fundamentalist communalism will weaken the Puranic sense of unity that is present among the people of India.



U.R. Ananthamurthy is a Kannada writer, poet and critic. He is a recipient of the Jnanpith Award and the Padma Bhushan.